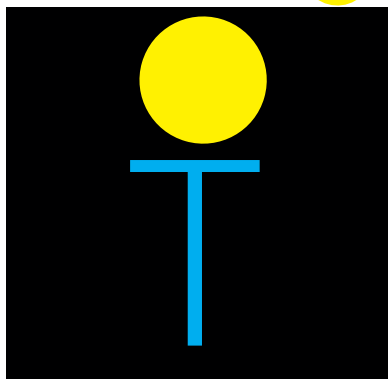




THE INDIAN GAMER WAS A RARE BREED even a decade ago. Not anymore. The country skipped a generation of gaming—PC and console-based games, which are popular in developed markets—and went directly to mobile gaming. It almost mirrors India’s mobile-first internet demographic, where hundreds of millions of users skipped desktops and laptops, and tasted the web for the first time on their smartphones.

Like many other industries, gaming has gained immeasurably from the penetration of cheap mobile data, which has lowered entry barriers for people. Anybody with even an entry-level smartphone can download a gaming app off the Google Play Store, and add to the burgeoning mobile gaming audience in the country.

India today is the world’s largest online gaming market by app downloads, according to analytics firm Sensor Tower. As of May 2022, the country accounted for 916 million installs, or 19.2 per cent of total worldwide downloads of games. In January, this number was at 761.8 million, or 14.6 per cent of global downloads, indicating steady growth. “The pandemic did one thing for the gaming industry—it converted non-gamers to casual gamers. Gaming companies were far more aggressive in pushing their games since people had more time on their hands,” says Gaurav Agarwal, Co-founder of Gamezop, a mobile gaming start-up. The monthly rate of non-gamers turning casual gamers may have come down now, “but those who became gamers during the lockdowns continue to game regularly,” he adds.

LOCKDOWNS AND BEYOND

In 2020, buoyed by the rapid growth in new users, downloads, and app engagement, online gaming as a segment outperformed most other media and entertainment (M&E) segments in India, according to KPMG. “The lockdowns were a tipping point for the industry, with [the number of] people playing online games higher by 20-25 per cent than pre-Covid-19 levels. The lack of physical social interaction coupled with increased disposable time at hand led to the growth of *Ludo King* and other social games during 2020 and 2021,” says a KPMG spokesperson. “These games have been going strong since then.”

India’s online gaming market was estimated at ₹14,500-15,500 crore at the end of FY22, as per KPMG. There are 430-460 million gamers, with more than 90 per cent being mobile or casual gamers. KPMG expects this number to touch 600-650 million by FY25.

Take *Ludo King*, for instance. A ‘lockdown sensation’ and India’s most downloaded game of all time, it crossed 800 million global



Vishal Gondal
Chief Executive
Officer, nCORE
Games

“CURRENTLY, INDIANS ARE CONSUMING GAMES AT AN UNPARALLELED, NEVER-BEFORE-SEEN PACE. ARPU GROWTH IN INDIA IS AT THE HIGHEST LEVEL COMPARED TO OTHER TOP ECONOMIES”